“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 7

Vallabha Bhaṭṭa Meets Śrī Caitanya

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship those who lick the honey of Śrī Caitanya’s lotus feet: by their mercy alone even a wretched soul becomes immortal.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 The next year all the devotees of Gauḍa came, and Mahāprabhu met them all as before.

4 While the Lord was thus enjoying His pastimes with the devotees, Vallabha Bhaṭṭa came to meet Him.

5 Coming before the Lord, the Bhaṭṭa bowed at His feet, and the Lord embraced him, regarding him as a *bhāgavata*, a devotee.

6 Showing him honor, the Lord seated him near Himself, and the Bhaṭṭa humbly began to speak.

7 “For many days I have longed to see You. Jagannātha has fulfilled my desire: I have seen You.

8 Whoever obtains Your sight is fortunate. When I see You, it is as if I see Bhagavān Himself.

9 Whoever remembers You becomes pure. What wonder, then, that one becomes pure by seeing You?

10 “Merely by remembering them, the homes of men at once become pure. How much more, then, by seeing them, touching them, washing their feet, offering them a seat and so on!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.19.33)

11 The *dharma* of the age of Kali is the *saṅkīrtana* of Kṛṣṇa’s name. Without Kṛṣṇa’s power no one can propagate it.

12 You have propagated it — that is the proof. You bear Kṛṣṇa’s power; of this there is no doubt.

13 You have made Kṛṣṇa’s name manifest in the world. Whoever sees You floats in love for Kṛṣṇa.

14 Without Kṛṣṇa’s power *prema* is not manifested. Kṛṣṇa alone is the giver of *prema* — so the scriptures testify.

15 “Let there be many all-auspicious avatāras of the Lord whose navel is a lotus; but who other than Kṛṣṇa gives prema even to the creepers?” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, 1.5.37)”

16 Mahāprabhu said, “Listen, wise Bhaṭṭa. I am a Māyāvādī *sannyāsī*; I do not know devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

17 Advaitācārya Gosāñi is Īśvara Himself, and in His company My mind became pure.

18 In all the scriptures and in devotion to Kṛṣṇa He has no equal; therefore His name is Advaita Ācārya, the peerless teacher.

19 By His mercy even *mlecchas* gain devotion to Kṛṣṇa. Who can describe the power of His Vaiṣṇava nature?

20 Nityānanda Avadhūta is Īśvara Himself. Intoxicated with the madness of ecstatic emotion (*bhāva*), He is an ocean of love for Kṛṣṇa.

21 Sārvabhauma Bhaṭṭācārya knows the six systems of philosophy (*darśanas*). In these six systems he is the guru of the world, and he is the best of *bhāgavatas*.

22 He showed Me the farthest limit of *bhakti-yoga*; by his grace I came to know that the *yoga* of devotion to Kṛṣṇa is the essence.

23 Rāmānanda Rāya is a treasury of the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa. He made Me understand that Kṛṣṇa is Bhagavān Himself.

24 Through him I came to know that *prema-bhakti* is the crown jewel of the goals of life (*puruṣārthas*), and that *prema-bhakti* on the path of spontaneous attraction (*rāga*) is the highest of all.

25 Servitude, friendship, parental love and the love of the beloved (*śṛṅgāra*) — of these the servant, the friend, the elder and the beloved are the shelter (*āśraya*).

26 There is *bhāva* joined with the knowledge of majesty, and there is pure (*kevala*) *bhāva*. By the knowledge of majesty one does not attain the son of the king of Vraja.

27 “This Bhagavān, the son of the gopī, is not so easily attained by the embodied, nor by the jñānīs, nor by those who have realized the self, as He is by those who have devotion.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.9.21)

28 The word *ātma-bhūta* means His associates. Because of her knowledge of His majesty, Lakṣmī did not attain the son of the king of Vraja.

29 “At the festival of the rāsa dance He embraced the beautiful women of Vraja around their necks with His arms, and they attained their heart’s desire. Such favour was not granted even to Śrī, who is wholly devoted to Him, nor to the celestial women, fragrant and radiant like lotuses — what then of others?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.47.60)

30 In pure *bhāva* His friend climbs on His shoulders, and in pure *bhāva* the queen of Vraja binds Him.

31 ‘My friend,’ ‘my son’ — such is the pure mind. Therefore Śuka and Vyāsa praise it.

32 “Thus the cowherd boys, who had amassed heaps of pious deeds, played with Him who is to the sages the experience of Brahman’s bliss, to those who have taken up His service the Supreme Deity, and to those under the spell of *māyā* a human child.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.12.11)

33 “She looked upon Hari, whose glory is sung by the three Vedas, the Upaniṣads, the works on Sāṅkhya and yoga and the Sātvata scriptures, as her own son.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.8.45)

34 “O brāhmaṇa, what good deed did Nanda perform to win such great fortune? And what did the most fortunate Yaśodā do, that Hari Himself drank from her breast?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.8.46)

35 Even when he sees Kṛṣṇa’s majesty, one whose *bhāva* is pure has no awareness of it. Therefore pure *bhāva* is superior to the mood of majesty.

36 All this Rāya Rāmānanda taught Me, and to hear it is supreme bliss.

37 Rāmānanda's power cannot be described. By Rāya's grace I came to know the pure *bhāva* of Vraja.

38 Dāmodara Svarūpa is the *rasa* of *prema* embodied. In his company I came to know the sweet *rasa* (*madhura-rasa*) of Vraja.

39 The pure *prema* of the goddesses of Vraja is without even a trace of lust (*kāma*). Its sign is this: its only aim is Kṛṣṇa's happiness.

40 "O dear one, Your tender lotus feet we place gently on our hard breasts, afraid to hurt them — and with those feet You wander through the forest! Are they not hurt by the sharp pebbles? You are our very life, and our minds are reeling." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.31.19)

41 "Disregarding husbands, sons, kin, brothers and relatives, we have come to Your side, O Acyuta, enchanted by Your song. You know why we have come. O cheat, who would abandon women at night?" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.31.16)

42 This worship is the highest of all, surpassing every form of *bhakti*. Therefore Kṛṣṇa says, 'I am your debtor.'

43 "O gopīs, your union with Me is faultless. Even in a lifetime of the gods I could not repay you for what you have done: you cut the fetters of home, so hard to break, and came to Me. So let your own good deed be your reward." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.32.22)

44 Pure *bhāva* is superior to the knowledge of majesty. On earth there is no devotee equal to Uddhava,

45 yet he prays for the dust of their feet. All this I learned in the company of Svarūpa.

46 Haridāsa Ṭhākura is the foremost of the great *bhāgavatas*. Every day he chants three lakhs (three hundred thousand) of names.

47 From him I learned the glory of the name; by his grace I came to know the glory of the name.

48 Ācāryaratna, Ācāryanidhi, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Jagadānanda, Dāmodara, Śaṅkara, Vakreśvara,

49 Kāśīśvara, Mukunda, Vāsudeva, Murāri and all the other devotees who descended in Gauḍa

50 have preached the name of Kṛṣṇa and *prema* throughout the world. It is in the company of all of them that I have My devotion to Kṛṣṇa."

51 Knowing the firm pride in the Bhaṭṭa's heart, Mahāprabhu spoke these words indirectly, to hint at it.

52 'I am a Vaiṣṇava; I know all the conclusions of *bhakti*. I am the one who explains the meaning of the Bhāgavata excellently' —

53 such was the long-standing pride in the Bhaṭṭa's mind. Hearing the Lord's words, that pride was humbled.

54 Hearing from the Lord's own mouth about the Vaiṣṇava qualities of all these devotees, the Bhaṭṭa wished to see them all.

55 The Bhaṭṭa said, "Where do all these Vaiṣṇavas live? How can I see them?"

56 The Lord said, "Some live in Gauḍa, some in other lands, but all have come to see the Ratha-yātrā.

57 They are all staying here, in lodgings in various places. Here you will be able to see them all.”

58 Then the Bhaṭṭa spoke many humble words and earnestly invited the Lord to a meal.

59 The next day all the Vaiṣṇavas came to the Lord, and Mahāprabhu introduced the Bhaṭṭa to them all.

60 Seeing the radiance of the Vaiṣṇavas, the Bhaṭṭa was amazed: before them all he was like a firefly.

61 Then the Bhaṭṭa had a great quantity of *mahā-prasāda* brought and fed Mahāprabhu and His associates.

62 The *sannyāsīs*, with Paramānanda Purī, all sat on one side to eat.

63 Advaita and Nityānanda Rāya sat at either side of Him; Mahāprabhu sat in the middle, with the devotees in front and behind.

64 I cannot tell how many devotees from Gauḍa there were; they all sat in rows in the courtyard.

65 Seeing the Lord’s devotees, the Bhaṭṭa was amazed, and in the Lord’s presence he bowed at the feet of them all.

66 Svarūpa, Jagadānanda, Kāśīśvara and Śaṅkara served the food, and so did Rāghava and Dāmodara.

67 Vallabha Bhaṭṭa had brought a great deal of *mahā-prasāda*, and the *sannyāsīs* sat down with the Lord to eat.

68 The Vaiṣṇavas honored the *prasāda*, saying “Hari! Hari!”, and the sound of “Hari” rose and filled the whole universe.

69 He brought plenty of garlands, sandal paste, areca nuts and betel leaves. Honoring everyone with them, the Bhaṭṭa was filled with joy.

70 On the day of the Ratha-yātrā the Lord began the *kīrtana*. As before, He formed seven separate groups.

71 Advaita, Nityānanda, Haridāsa, Vakreśvara, Śrīvāsa, Rāghava and Gadādhara Paṇḍita —

72 these seven led the *kīrtana* in seven places, and the Lord moved from group to group, calling “Hari bol!”

73 Fourteen *mādalas* (drums) sounded in the loud *saṅkīrtana*, and the world floated in the *prema* of each of the dancers.

74 Seeing this, Vallabha Bhaṭṭa was amazed. Overwhelmed with bliss, he lost all composure.

75 Then Mahāprabhu stopped everyone’s dancing, and the Bhaṭṭa was amazed at the Lord’s conduct.

76 At another festival the Bhaṭṭa went to Mahāprabhu and submitted a request at His feet:

77 “I have written something of a commentary on the Bhāgavata. Would You, Mahāprabhu, hear it Yourself?”

78 The Lord said, “I cannot understand the meaning of the Bhāgavata. I am not qualified even to hear its meaning.

79 I simply sit and chant Kṛṣṇa's name, and even so, night and day, I cannot complete My fixed number of names."

80 The Bhaṭṭa said, "I have explained the meaning of Kṛṣṇa's name at length. Please hear that."

81 The Lord said, "I do not accept many meanings of Kṛṣṇa's name. I know only this: Śyāmasundara, the dark and beautiful One, and Yaśodā-nandana, the son of Yaśodā.

82 "The conventional meaning (*rūḍhi*) of the name 'Kṛṣṇa' is He whose luster is dark like a *tamāla* tree and who drinks at the breast of Śrī Yaśodā: this is the conclusion of all the scriptures." (Nāma-kaumudī)

83 This meaning alone I know as settled; I have no qualification for any other meanings."

84 The Bhaṭṭa's explanations of the name and the rest were all nearly worthless (*phalgu*). Knowing this, the all-knowing Lord disregarded them.

85 Dejected, the Bhaṭṭa went home, and his devotion to the Lord partly ebbed away.

86 Then the Bhaṭṭa went to Paṇḍita Gosāñi. Showing friendship in many ways, he kept coming and going.

87 Because the Lord disregarded him, none of the people of Nīlācala would listen to the Bhaṭṭa's explanations.

88 The Bhaṭṭa felt ashamed and dishonored, and in his grief he went to the Paṇḍita.

89 Humbly he said, “I have taken shelter of you. Be merciful and save my life.

90 If you will hear my explanation of Kṛṣṇa’s name, the mire of my shame will be washed away.”

91 The Paṇḍita was caught in a dilemma and full of doubt: he could not decide what he should do.

92 Although the Paṇḍita did not consent, the Bhaṭṭa came and read to him anyway, forcing it on him.

93 Out of noble courtesy (*ābhijātya*) the Paṇḍita could not forbid him. “Kṛṣṇa, protect me in this dilemma,” he prayed. “I have taken shelter of You.

94 The Lord dwells in the heart; He will know my mind, and I have no fear of Him. But His associates are ‘severe.’”

95 Although on consideration the Paṇḍita was not at fault, the Lord’s associates still showed him an anger born of love (*praṇaya-roṣa*).

96 Every day Vallabha Bhaṭṭa came to the Lord and started disputes, as it were, with the Ācārya and others.

97 Whatever ‘conclusion’ (*siddhānta*) the Bhaṭṭa tried to establish, the Ācārya refuted the moment he heard it.

98 Whenever the Bhaṭṭa came before the Ācārya and the others, he was like a heron among royal swans.

99 One day the Bhaṭṭa asked the Ācārya: “The *jīva* is *prakṛti*, the female, and accepts Kṛṣṇa as her husband (*pati*).

100 A wife devoted to her husband does not utter her husband's name. Yet you utter Kṛṣṇa's name — what sort of *dharma* is that?"

101 The Ācārya said, "Before you stands *dharma* embodied. Ask Him; He will resolve the question."

102 The Lord said, "You do not know what is *dharma* and what is *adharma*. A faithful wife's *dharma* is to follow her husband's order.

103 The husband's order is to utter his name ceaselessly, and a faithful wife cannot transgress her husband's order.

104 Therefore she utters the name and gains the fruit of the name: by that fruit love (*prema*) for Kṛṣṇa's feet awakens."

105 Hearing this, Vallabha Bhaṭṭa fell silent. He went home and brooded sorrowfully:

106 "Every day I am defeated in this assembly. If only my word would prevail just once,

107 I would be happy, and all my shame would be gone. What means can I find to establish my own view?"

108 The next day he came, bowed to the Lord, and sat down. Then, proud at heart, he spoke in the assembly:

109 "In the Bhāgavata I have refuted Śrīdhara Svāmī's explanations. I cannot accept the words of his commentary.

110 He explains whatever passage he takes up just as it stands there; there is no consistency in it. Therefore I do not accept Svāmī."

111 The Lord smiled and said, “Whoever does not accept the *svāmī* (the husband), I count among prostitutes.”

112 Having said this, Mahāprabhu fell silent. Hearing it, everyone was satisfied at heart.

113 Gaura descended for the good of the world, and He knew the pride hidden in the Bhaṭṭa’s heart.

114 By various kinds of disregard Bhagavān purified the Bhaṭṭa, just as Kṛṣṇa broke the pride of Indra.

115 An ignorant *jīva* takes his own good for harm. When his pride has been crushed, his eyes open at last.

116 Back at home that night, the Bhaṭṭa began to think: “Earlier, in Prayāga, the Lord showed me great mercy.

117 With His associates He accepted my invitation. Why has the Lord’s mind now turned against me?

118 ‘May his mind become free of this pride — “I shall win”’: such is His intention. It is the Lord’s nature to do good to all.

119 To make a name for myself, I give way to pride; to break that pride, He dishonors me.

120 He is doing me good, yet I take it as sorrow — just as Indra, that great fool, behaved toward Kṛṣṇa.”

121 Thinking this, he came to the Lord in the morning and, humbly offering praise, took shelter at His feet.

122 “I am an ignorant *jīva*, and I acted as the ignorant act. Fool that I am, I displayed my learning before You.

123 You are the Lord, and You showed mercy befitting Yourself: by dishonoring me, You broke all my pride.

124 I am ignorant: in place of good I saw dishonor, just as Indra blasphemed Kṛṣṇa in ignorance.

125 By the salve of Your mercy the blindness of my pride is gone. You have shown me such mercy that now true knowledge has come.

126 I have committed offenses; forgive me. I have taken shelter of You. Be merciful and place Your feet on my head.”

127 The Lord said, “You are a *paṇḍita* and a great devotee (*mahā-bhāgavata*). Where these two qualities are found, there can be no mountain of pride.

128 Yet you blaspheme Śrīdhara Svāmī and write your own commentary! You do not accept Śrīdhara Svāmī — such is the pride you hold!

129 By the grace of Śrīdhara Svāmī I understand the *Bhāgavata*. I accept Śrīdhara Svāmī, the guru of the world, as My guru.

130 Whatever anyone writes out of pride, setting himself above Śrīdhara, will be distorted in meaning (*artha-vyasta*), and people will not accept it.

131 But whoever writes in the footsteps of Śrīdhara, all people will honor and accept.

132 Explain the *Bhāgavata* in the footsteps of Śrīdhara. Give up your pride and worship Kṛṣṇa, Bhagavān.

133 Give up offenses and perform the *saṅkīrtana* of Kṛṣṇa. Then you will very soon attain the feet of Kṛṣṇa.”

134 The Bhaṭṭa said, “If You are now pleased with me, accept my invitation once again some day.”

135 The Lord has descended to deliver the world, so He accepted the invitation to give the Bhaṭṭa joy.

136 “May the world be blessed” — such is the Lord’s mind. Even when He punishes, He does so to purify a person’s heart.

137 The Bhaṭṭa invited the Lord together with His associates, and Mahāprabhu was then pleased with him.

138 Jagadānanda Paṇḍita’s *bhāva* was pure and deep. Like Satyabhāmā’s, his love had a contrary nature (*vāmya*).

139 Again and again he had loving quarrels with the Lord, and the two of them kept squabbling with each other.

140 Gadādhara Paṇḍita’s *bhāva* was pure and deep, with a compliant nature (*dakṣiṇa*) like that of Rukmiṇī-devī.

141 The Lord wanted to see his loving anger (*praṇaya-roṣa*), but because Gadādhara was conscious of the Lord’s majesty, anger never arose in him.

142 Taking this occasion, the Lord feigned anger, and when the Paṇḍita heard of it, fear arose in his heart.

143 So it was long ago: when Kṛṣṇa teased Rukmiṇī mockingly, fear arose in her mind as she heard Him.

144 Vallabha Bhaṭṭa worshiped in the mood of parental love (*vātsalya*); he served with the Bāla-gopāla mantra.

145 In the company of the Paṇḍita his mind changed, and he turned his mind to the worship of Kiśora-gopāla.

146 He wanted to receive the mantra and so on from the Paṇḍita, but the Paṇḍita said, “This is not for me to do.

147 I am dependent; my Lord is Gauracandra. Without His order I am not free to act on my own.

148 Just because you come to me, the Lord reproaches me.”

149 In this way some days passed for the Bhaṭṭa. At last the Lord became fully pleased with him.

150 On the day of the invitation the Lord called for the Paṇḍita, sending Svarūpa, Jagadānanda and Govinda to bring him.

151 On the way Svarūpa said to the Paṇḍita, “The Lord disregarded you to test you.

152 Why didn’t you come and reproach Him? Why did you put up with it, as if you were afraid?”

153 The Paṇḍita said, “The Lord is the crown jewel of the all-knowing. I do not think it right to be obstinate with Him.

154 Whatever He says, I bear it, holding it on my head. He Himself will weigh my merits and faults and show me mercy.”

155 Saying this, the Paṇḍita came to the Lord and, weeping, fell at His feet.

156 Smiling slightly, the Lord embraced him and spoke sweet words for all to hear:

157 “I showed you anger, but you were not moved. You said nothing in anger; you bore it all.

158 My gestures did not move your mind. By your firm, simple-hearted love you have bought Me.”

159 The marks of the Paṇḍita’s *bhāva* cannot be described; by them the Lord came to be named ‘Gadādhara-prāṇanātha’ (Lord of Gadādhara’s life).

160 The Lord’s favor to the Paṇḍita cannot be described. People sing of Him as ‘Gadāi-Gaurāṅga.’

161 Who can understand the pastimes of Caitanya Prabhu? In one pastime the Gaṅgā flows in hundreds and hundreds of streams.

162 The Lord made known to the world the Paṇḍita’s gentleness, his brahminical virtue, and the firm mark of his love.

163 Washing away the mire of pride, He purified the Bhaṭṭa, and by this He taught everyone else as well.

164 Within is grace; outwardly it looks like disregard. Whoever takes only the outer meaning is ruined.

165 Who has the power to understand the hidden pastimes of Caitanya? Only one whose devotion to Gauracandra is firm understands them.

166 On another day the Paṇḍita invited the Lord, and the Lord took His meal there together with the devotees.

167 There Vallabha Bhaṭṭa received the Lord’s permission, and from the Paṇḍita he obtained all he had long prayed for.

168 Thus I have told of Vallabha Bhaṭṭa’s meeting with the Lord. By hearing of it, one gains the treasure of love for Gaura.

169 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.